ITP METRICS
Growing your people and ours

Difficult Conversations: Ground Rules

- **Remember that the other person can't read your mind.** It's important that you state very clearly how you see the situation.
- **Don't belittle the person.** Your tone should be firm and direct – but never talk down to the other person.
- **State the facts clearly and in as few words as possible**. Once you have stated the facts, don't dwell on them.
- **Frame your concerns in a positive way.** Don't dwell on the difficult person's behavior. Instead, focus on how he or she can improve.
- **Consider the other person's self- esteem.** Choose your words carefully. Write them down ahead of time. Think how you would feel if someone said the same words to you.
- **Have a clear game plan in mind**. After you have explained the problem to the person and told him or her exactly what you want, include how you are prepared to help – and spell out a time frame in which change has to occur.

8 Process Guidelines

1. **Replace "but" with "and."**
"I agree with you but…" creates distrust and raises defenses. "And" leaves room for consideration of two points.
2. **Use "I" statements.**
"I believe…" is usually a more accurate and truthful statement than absolute statements such as "it is." Don't attribute problems to others that are your own.
3. **Don't disguise your opinions as questions.**
"Don't you think that…?" creates a defensive reaction and push people into corners. Be honest about your opinion instead with an "I" statement.
4. **Seek to understand before seeking to be understood.**
Be able to restate in your own words what the previous speaker said through active listening. This makes sure you understand before you question.
5. **Support your conclusions with data first, then emotions**
Recognize the difference between logic and emotion. Pressing a point filled with motion to make up for a lack of evidence will get you nowhere.
6. **Be descriptive, not judgmental.**
Instead of saying "John, you are lazy" say, "John, I noticed your last two assignments were late."
7. **Think creatively instead of critically.**
When you think critically you are listening for conformity and it prevents you from hearing new and innovative ideas or solutions to a problem.
8. **Accept responsibility for the content, process, and outcomes of every situation you are a part of.**
Ask yourself, "How did I contribute to the situation?